AJP Policy Overview

Protection of indigenous and non-indigenous wild animals

The Animal Justice Party (AJP) recognises all wild animals (indigenous and non-indigenous) as individuals with unique needs and value. We believe that within Aotearoa New Zealand both native and introduced animals have a right to live their lives unimpeded and unharmed by human activities. For the purpose of this document, 'wild animal' refers to free-living animals who live outside captivity and without direct human control, including feral animals.

AJP recognises there can be conflicts between endemic and introduced animals, while emphasising the need for solutions that prioritise compassion and protection. We reject divisive language, hunting and the glorification of trapping and killing animals for conservation purposes. Fundamentally, wild animals deserve the same rights to liberty, health, and freedom from harm as domesticated animals, and this should be reflected in law by specifically including them under the protection of the Animal Welfare Act, rather than considering them "pests" for eradication.

The health and integrity of these ecosystems are of value to New Zealanders and necessary to uphold the Crown's obligations under Te Tiriti o Waitangi, and are also vital for the flourishing of wild animals. For these reasons, AJP supports compassionate and just efforts to mitigate the threats that our ecosystems face.

AJP's policies for the protection of wild animals would best be implemented alongside a transition to a plant-based economy. This is important for three key reasons. Firstly, much of the funding for 'pest' control is allocated specifically to protect animal agricultural interests from disease vectors, particularly targeting possums and stoats which can carry bovine tuberculosis that affects farm animals.[1] This risk would naturally

[1] TBfree is co-funded by the Crown (appropriated via MPI's 'Biosecurity: Control of Bovine TB' vote) and by the dairy, beef, and deer sectors through levies on milk solids, cattle/deer slaughter, velvet, and live exports - roughly a 40% government / 60% industry split. See OSPRI. (n.d.). Funding the TBfree programme. https://www.ospri.co.nz/our-programmes/the-tbfree-programme/funding/; New Zealand Treasury. (2025). Supplementary Estimates of Appropriations 2024/25: Vote Agriculture, Biosecurity, Fisheries and Food Safety

be eliminated with the end of animal farming. Secondly, the focus on invasive species neglects the devastating impact that habitat loss has had on native fauna, which was primarily driven by the need to create pasture for animal farming.[2] Eliminating animal agriculture could free up enormous amounts of land for habitat restoration, supporting the protection of indigenous species. Thirdly, animal agriculture is the main cause of freshwater pollution, harming wild fish and eels, along with other freshwater species.[3]

Along with environmental protection, AJP supports research and innovation to develop compassionate and protective approaches within conservation practice.

AJP's ultimate vision is a harmonious coexistence between humans and other animals, fostering a society that upholds the wellbeing and protection of all species and protects the taonga status of specific animals in Aotearoa.

Four overarching objectives

Our policy for wild animals is focused on protecting and managing wildlife through humane and sustainable approaches that respect all animals as individuals with inherent value. It is centered around four objectives, each supported by specific proposals:

Key Objectives:

1. **Use compassionate approaches to manage introduced species**. Implement non-lethal, humane and species-specific methods to address challenges posed by introduced animals while recognising their right to live without unnecessary harm.

2. **Protect and restore natural habitats.** Preserve and enhance the environments where wild animals thrive, using whole-ecosystem approaches that benefit both native and introduced species.

3. **Shield wild animals from human-caused harms**. Mandate practices that minimise the negative impacts of human activities, development and pollution on wild animals and their habitats.

(includes "Biosecurity: Control of Bovine TB").
https://budget.govt.nz/budget/pdfs/suppestimates/suppest25agbiofifoo.pdf

[2] Julia Haggerty and Hugh Campbell, 'Farming and the environment', Te Ara - the Encyclopedia of New Zealand, http://www.TeAra.govt.nz/en/farming-and-the-environment/print (accessed 15 February 2025); this point is further elaborated under Objective 2.

[3] Wang, W. F. (2024). Eutrophication mechanisms and their impacts on coastal marine ecosystems. International Journal of Marine Science, 14(4), 285–294. https://doi.org/10.5376/ijms.2024.14.0032

4. **Mitigate natural threats to wild animal populations.** Support research and intervention programs that help protect wild animals from disease, natural disasters and other environmental challenges while respecting natural processes.